Forking Machine



Category: **Power Tools & Workshop Machines** Type: **Full SOP** Priority: **High** 2 labs

Covers these lab items: Forking machine

What it is used for

A forking machine is used to lift, move, position, or handle materials using forks or fork-shaped attachments. Operate it only within its rated capacity and according to the specific machine design and manufacturer instructions.

Main parts

- Forks or fork-shaped material-handling attachment
- Mast, lifting mechanism, or support frame
- Hydraulic or mechanical operating controls
- Drive wheels, base, or supporting structure
- Power unit or drive mechanism, if fitted
- Safety guards, handles, and emergency stop, if fitted

Before you start

1. Identify the machine type and read its operating instructions.
2. Inspect forks, frame, fasteners, wheels, and lifting components for damage.
3. Check hydraulic lines, electrical cables, or mechanical parts as applicable.
4. Confirm the rated capacity and suitability for the intended load.
5. Ensure the route and work area are level, clear, and well lit.
6. Wear suitable PPE and keep unauthorised people away from the work area.

How to use

1. Position the machine on a stable surface and apply its parking or stabilising system, if fitted.
2. Complete the pre-use inspection and confirm all controls operate correctly.
3. Check that the load is stable, within capacity, and suitable for the forks.
4. Approach the load slowly and align the forks with the designated lifting points.
5. Insert the forks fully beneath or into the approved load support points.
6. Secure the load using the machine's approved method, where applicable.
7. Lift the load gradually and check for instability before moving.
8. Move at a controlled speed while keeping the load as low as the design allows.
9. Avoid sudden turns, impacts, and movements that could shift the load.
10. Position the load over the designated drop-off area.
11. Lower the load gently until it is fully supported and stable.
12. Withdraw the forks carefully without dragging or tipping the load.
13. Return the machine to its designated parking area and lower the forks.

4. Switch off or isolate the machine as instructed and report any faults.

⚠ Safety

- Only trained and authorised operators should use the machine.
- Never exceed the rated load or use damaged or modified forks.
- Keep hands, feet, and other body parts clear of moving forks and mechanisms.
- Never stand or walk beneath a raised load.
- Do not carry people unless the machine is specifically designed and approved for that purpose.
- Use the required stabilisers and follow site rules for slopes and uneven surfaces.

Care & storage

- Clean dirt and debris from forks, wheels, and moving parts after use.
- Inspect lifting components, fasteners, and controls regularly.
- Check hydraulic or electrical systems according to the maintenance schedule.
- Lubricate service points only as specified by the manufacturer.
- Record defects and remove unsafe equipment from service.

Common mistakes to avoid

- Lifting a load beyond the machine's rated capacity.
- Moving with a raised or unstable load.
- Using the machine without inspecting forks and lifting components.
- Standing beneath a raised load or allowing others into the hazard area.

Disclaimer: This SOP is prepared from general information available on the internet. For detailed instructions, refer to the manufacturer's original manual / file.